The duel, which echoes a wider debate, is between two partners in the ruling National Democratic Alliance (NDA). Chirag heads the Lok Janshakti Party (Ram Vilas); Suman's father, also a Union minister, helms the Hindustani Awam Morcha (Secular). The two find their primary base at different ends of the Dalit spectrum: LJP(RV) among the relatively dominant Paswans or Dusadhs, HAM(S) from the Mahadalits, with Manjhi's Musahar community a canonical example of those furthest from social privilege.

Takeaways

- **Chirag and Manjhi's son Suman in intense debate**
- **HAM(S) wants sub-quotas, LJP warns of splintering**
- **Key issue: can SC quota have deprivation ladder?**

In August, Chirag upped the ante by asking Manjhi and son to give up their posts if they wish to introduce a 'creamy layer' among the SCs. Suman critiqued Chirag's line, saying a sub-quota is "poles apart" from that concept, since it sub-classifies *jatis*—as against the creamy layer, which debars better-off *individuals*.

'NO THREAT TO QUOTAS'

It is much less a hostile means to end reservations—according to this line—and only wants to ensure the most deprived receive their due share. Those who flag it as a species threat to quotas are trying to frighten the poor, says Suman. Citing a 2024 Supreme Court judgment allowing states to sub-classify SCs, he asks why Bihar cannot follow Haryana, Andhra Pradesh, Telangana and Tamil Nadu, states that have moved in that direction. If representation by numbers is accepted as a larger principle of social justice, Suman's question is: why should representation by relative deprivation of castes be treated as an assault on reservation?

THE MAHADALIT RIDDLE

This cuts to the heart of the dilemma. The court order prescribes the deprivation index as a marker to correct representation imbalances. That seems coherent with natural justice, in a scenario where better-placed castes have managed better access to quotas, gaining a bigger share than their population may warrant.

Yet, it also introduces an economic criterion on the lines used for the Other Backward Classes (OBCs) into Dalit quota: a realm explicitly designed to right historical wrongs of a social kind. That will be implicitly fulfilled with a protected share for, say, Musahars, who are in generous receipt of caste stigmas. But deprivation will be translated into a numerical share, and that will come at the cost of other Dalits.

Dalits, split into 22 castes, are 19.65 per cent of Bihar's population: Dusadhs are 5.31 per cent, Ravidasis 5.25 per cent, Musahars 3.08 per cent. Only 1.13 per cent of Bihar's 25.6 million Dalits, around 291,000 people, hold government jobs—some 99,830 Dusadhs and 82,290 Ravidasis among them. Of the 4 million-plus Musahars, only 10,615 figured on the roster—an unconscionable 0.26 per cent.

A blanket refusal to count deprivation reproduces this inequality, says HAM(S). Chirag echoes his late father Ram Vilas's warning on ex-CM Nitish Kumar's Mahadalit idea: split quotas, and you fragment Dalit solidarity as a bloc for good. ■



CRASHING JCBs bring down a mosque in the Saharanpur Collectorate complex, Sept. 5

By **Avaneesh Mishra**

LIKE A MUCH-ENACTED PLAY, IT TOOK THE SAHARANPUR administration barely a morning to pull down a mosque that had stood inside the Collectorate complex for over a century. The rest of the script, too, evoked déjà vu: the judicial route along which the JCBs trundled in, the summary execution, the angry declamations from the Opposition about "selective justice". So familiar was it all for Uttar Pradesh that one could almost say, 'situation normal'. Yet, it is not. There's something missing in the air, a muted anxiety that lends the ritual re-enactment of a Hindutva set-piece a kind of urgency it has not known before.

It's not particularly novel in these parts to have the abrupt effacement of a masjid as a necessary preface to Hindutva consolidation. In Saharanpur, the case had begun with a 2025 complaint by a Bajrang Dal functionary. It moved through a city magistrate's order branding the structure "unauthorised" and imposing a penalty of over Rs 6 crore, and ended with the district court dismissing the mosque committee's final appeal. Three days later, the bulldozers arrived—before dawn, with police cover.

The clockwork precision points at